

Naval Messaging / Communications

Complete Study Guide - all information covered in our notes and discussion

Course-context guide: This version prioritizes the terminology in the handwritten class notes you supplied. Some Navy organizations, markings, and legacy systems change over time; for your exam, use your instructor's course wording.

1. Naval Communications Mission and References

Main mission: Provide reliable, secure, and rapid communications based on wartime requirements.

Communications: Internal and external. Your notes use phones as an internal example and external communications as ship-to-ship / off-ship communications.

NTP-1: Described in class notes as the 'Bible for Comms.' Chapters 3, 5, and 7 were specifically noted. **NTP-4:** referenced for manual procedures.

ACP 131F: Communications instructions / operating signals; your notes call these Q and Z signals.

2. Major Networks, Systems, and Organizations

Term	Meaning	Course purpose / key point
DCS	Defense Communications System	Supports the military departments - Navy, Army, Air Force - and other DoD activities.
DISA	Defense Information Systems Agency	Provides operational direction to the DCS.
NIPRNET	Non-classified Internet Protocol Router Network	Day-to-day unclassified network; long-haul IP-based network supporting unclassified IP data communications.
SIPRNET	Secret Internet Protocol Router Network	DoD interoperable command-and-control data network for SECRET traffic; supports global command and control systems.
JWICS	Joint Worldwide Intelligence Communications System	Supports Sensitive Compartmented Information (SCI); advanced networking for point-to-point or multipoint exchange including voice, text, graphics, data, video, and teleconferencing.
NAVFOR / U.S. Fleet Forces	Naval / Fleet Forces context	Train, certify, and provide combat-ready Navy forces capable of prompt, sustained naval, joint, and combined operations.
NCDOC	Navy Cyber Defense Operations Command	Cyber-defense function; notes associate it with reporting/defense against viruses, phishing, and similar threats.
NCMS	Naval Communications Material System	Course notes associate NCMS with communications equipment/circuits - think physical communications material.
NCTAMS	Naval Computer and Telecommunications Area Master Station	Operates and maintains responsive information-transfer systems providing real-time C4I information support to the fleet.
NCTS	Naval Computer and Telecommunications Station	Provides Naval IT infrastructure/support services for rapid and reliable voice/data communications within an assigned AOR.
NIOC	Navy Information Operations Command	Notes associate NIOC with support to Navy information operations and SIGINT.
JFTOC	Joint Fleet Telecommunications Operations Center	Watch officer coordinates telecommunications functions ashore and maintains real-time operational status of circuits providing telecommunications.
FLTNOG	Fleet Network Operations Center	Helps with network issues; notes identify regional NOCs such as European, Indian Ocean, Pacific, and unified Atlantic.

NCTAMS / NCTS facts from class notes

NCTAMS master stations: LANT - Norfolk, Virginia; PAC - Wahiawa, Hawaii.

NCTS locations listed in the notes (7): Jacksonville, FL; San Diego, CA; Bahrain; Guam; Naples, Italy; Far East / Yokosuka, Japan; Sicily.

NCTS mission: Provide Naval information-technology infrastructure and support services required for rapid and reliable voice and data communications within a specified Area of Responsibility (AOR).

3. Communications Chain of Command / Watchstanding

Position	Meaning	Responsibilities / exam cue
CO	Commanding Officer	Overall authority. Your notes emphasize: overall responsibility is the CO.
COMMO	Communications Officer	Officer overseeing the command's communications organization. Notes identify an officer position.
RO	Radio Officer - Large Deck	Large-deck radio officer; on smaller ships COMMO and RO may be the same person.
CWO	Communications Watch Officer	Course notes: highest qualified enlisted person in Radio; notes associate CWO with E4-E6.
Technical Control Supervisor	Technical Control Supervisor	Works for / supports CWO; establishes and maintains required circuits and initiates action to restore or bypass failed equipment.

Radio Officer duties from your notes

- Prepare the command's communications plan.
- Monitor proper allocation of equipment for operations.
- Prepare and maintain the communications watch quarter and station bill.
- Conduct communications training programs.
- Prepare Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs) for the communications center.
- On small ships, the Communications Officer and Radio Officer may be the same person.

CWO / Technical Control

CWO: Ensures communications capabilities are accomplished in accordance with the command's mission; handles incoming/outgoing traffic, existing communications devices, and manual procedures. **Technical Control Supervisor:** responsible to the CWO for establishing and maintaining required circuits and taking action to restore or bypass failed equipment.

Common shipboard radio tasks

Qualifications, operating procedures, logs, communications/network maintenance, deck watches, and damage-control responsibilities.

4. CMS / COMSEC

Term	Meaning / Responsibilities
COMSEC	Communications Security - protection of communications and associated information/material.
CMS Custodian	Communications Security Material System Custodian. Advises the CO on physical security and handling of crypto/CMS publications and materials; manages the CMS account; controls storage; performs required reporting.
Inventory / watch turnover	Before someone assumes the watch, your notes emphasize completing inventory with two people - the person assuming the watch and a witness.
Logs / MSL	Master Station Log (MSL). Notes say erasures are not allowed. Examples logged: new radio day, watch turnover, messages received, circuit status, inventories, and significant events.
Central Message Log	Used specifically for messages.

5. Three Types of Naval Messages

Type	Meaning	Purpose / memory cue
GENSER	General Service / general messages	Course notes: general messages from UNCLASSIFIED through TOP SECRET. Think normal/general official message traffic.
DSSCS	Defense Special Security Communications System	Associated with SI / Sensitive Compartmented Information (SCI). Think special intelligence communications.
CRITIC	Critical intelligence communications/reporting	Rapid, short, fast reporting of critical events/situations to senior government decision-makers.

6. Message Drafting Roles

Role	Definition
Originator	The command originating the message - e.g., ship/base/command. Your notes emphasize the name of the ship/base or command.

Role	Definition
Drafter	The person who drafts/writes the message.
Releaser	The person authorized to release the message. Not everyone has release authority.

Memory sequence: Originator needs/sponsors it -> Drafter writes it -> Releaser authorizes it. Your notes indicate the same person can sometimes perform all three roles.

7. Special Handling Markings

Marking	Meaning / course note
RD	Restricted Data - notes associate this with nuclear information.
FRD	Formerly Restricted Data - no longer RD but still requires safeguarding.
FOUO	For Official Use Only - legacy unclassified handling marking in your course notes.
EFTO	Encrypt / Encrypted For Transmission Only - unclassified material requiring encryption for transmission; notes describe information with potential intelligence value that does not meet classification criteria.
SPECAT	Special Category - classified messages identified with a special project/subject. Notes list Limited Distribution, NATO Restricted, Personal For, and Allied Restricted.
COMMSHIFT	Communications Guard Shift message - used when shifting communications guard from one station/NCTAMS to another.
COMMSPOT	Used to advise of a situation that might cause significant disruption of tactical communications; notes associate reports with communications status.

8. Naval Message Addressing

Term	Meaning	Course distinction
NAVMACS	Naval Modular Automated Communications System	Provides accurate, secure, expedient communications for various classes of ships and flagships.
PLA	Plain Language Address	Name of a single command / one command.
AIG	Address Indicator Group	Notes: group addressing involving 16 or more commands / PLAs.
CAD	Collective Address Designator	Notes: 4 or more PLAs within the group sharing a chain of command.

9. GENSER IP Message Format

The numbered format lines below reproduce the items captured in your class notes. Lines not supplied in the notes are intentionally not invented.

Line	Element	What to remember
1	Transmission Identification	Transmission-identification information.
2	Message Header	Coded message header; detailed character positions below.
4	Security Warning	First three letters identify security handling. Notes: ZNR = unclassified; ZNY = classified.
5	Date-Time Group (DTG)	Day / hour / minute / time zone / month / year. Represents message date/time.
6	FM / FROM	Originator - command sending the message.
7	TO	Action addressee - who the message is directed to / who must act.
8	INFO	Information addressee - receives for awareness; notes compare it to CC.
11	BT / BREAK	Break separating heading/address information from the message body.
12	Text / Body	Actual message body; includes SUBJ, REF, AMPN, NARR, RMKS.
13	BT / BREAK	Break after the message body.
14	SSN	Sequence/serial number; notes describe it as number of message per month.
16	NNNN	End of message.

Format Line 2 - Message Header Character Positions

Position	Meaning	Notes
Next 2 letters	Header characters	Notes show 'TT' as the next two letters in the header.
4th character	Classification	U = Unclassified; C = Confidential; S = Secret; T = Top Secret.
5-8	Content Indicator Code (CIC)	Tells what kind of message it is.
9 and 21	Blank spaces	Always blank spaces per notes.
10-15	OSRI	Originating Station Routing Indicator.
17-20	SSN	Sequence/serial number; number of message per month.
22-24	Julian Date	Day of the year.
25-28	Time Filed	GMT / UTC / Zulu time.
29-33	Classification repeated	Classification character repeated in this field.
34	Routing Indicator	Notes: indicates where the message is going to end.
End	Period (.)	A period is always at the end.

Classification memory colors from class notes

U - Unclassified = green; C - Confidential = blue; S - Secret = red; T - Top Secret = orange.

Format Line 5 - DTG

DTG order: Day - Hour - Minute - Time Zone - Month - Year. Example structure from the notes: DDHHMMZ MON YY. Z indicates Zulu time.

Format Line 12 - Body Components

Abbreviation	Meaning / note
SUBJ	Subject
REF	Reference
AMPN	Amplification - your notes say used when there is only one reference.
NARR	Narrative
RMKS	Remarks

10. Operating Signals - ACP 131F

Your notes identify ACP 131F operating signals as **Q and Z signals**. These are standardized procedural signals used in communications.

Signal	Course-note meaning
INT QSL	Interrogative form asking for acknowledgment / whether received.
QSL	I acknowledge / I received your transmission.
INT QBZ	Interrogative signal used in your notes as the start of a procedural exchange.
55555	Response shown in your notes to the INT QBZ example.
ZUG	No.
ZUE	Yes.
ZUJ	Stand by.
ZUJ 1	Wait one.
ZBZ	Question concerning printing/acceptability of signals, as phrased in the class notes.

11. Logs, Minimize, and Operational Notes

Topic	Course note
Master Station Log (MSL)	No erasures. Records new radio day, watch turnover, messages received, circuit status, inventories, and significant events.
Central Message Log	Just for messages.
MINIMIZE	Condition used when communications capacity must be conserved; notes mention an enemy-nearby scenario and limiting messages to roughly 100-200 words, emphasizing FLASH and IMMEDIATE traffic.
SOP	Standard Operating Procedure - tells you step-by-step how to perform the procedure.
PQS	Personnel Qualification Standards; notes associate PQS with communications/network maintenance, deck watches, and damage control.

12. Fast Memorization Page

Networks: NIPR = Unclassified | SIPR = Secret | JWICS = SCI

Message types: GENSER = General | DSSCS = SCI/Special | CRITIC = Critical intelligence

Drafting: Originator -> Drafter -> Releaser

Addressing: PLA = one command | AIG = large address group | CAD = collective group

Watch chain: CO -> COMMO -> RO (Large Deck) -> CWO -> Technical Control Supervisor

GENSER key lines: 4 Security | 5 DTG | 6 FROM | 7 TO | 8 INFO | 11 BT | 12 BODY | 13 BT | 14 SSN | 16 NNNN

Body: SUBJ -> REF -> AMPN -> NARR -> RMKS

Special handling: RD | FRD | FOUO | EFTO | SPECAT | COMMSHIFT | COMMSPOT

13. Items to Treat as Course-Specific

Several terms in Naval communications are legacy, command-specific, or may have changed organizationally. For this exam guide, the definitions above reflect the handwritten class notes. In particular, use the instructor's wording for NCMS, regional FLTNOC names, AIG/CAD thresholds, legacy FOUO usage, and the exact GENSER header fields.